B2 Listening

Catching numbers and statistics

Note percentages, large numbers, dates and trends accurately in a short news report.

Reports and lectures are full of numbers, and they go past quickly. Prepare for the forms numbers take, and listen for the words that tell you whether a figure rose or fell.

Type	How it sounds	Written
Percentages	*twelve point five per cent*	12.5%
Large numbers	*three point two million*	3,200,000
Fractions	*nearly a third, more than half*	about 33%, over 50%
Years	*twenty twenty-four, two thousand and nine*	2024, 2009
Trends	*rose, climbed, fell, dropped, remained steady*	up, down, no change

Listen

▼ **Show transcript**

Tourism figures for last year are now in. The country welcomed three point two million visitors, up from two point eight million the year before. Hotel occupancy rose to seventy-four per cent, while the average stay fell slightly, from five nights to four point six. Visitors from Europe made up more than half of the total, and nearly a third came from other Gulf countries. Officials expect numbers to climb again this year, aiming for four million by twenty twenty-seven.

Write the number first, then the trend. Jot *3.2m ↑ (2.8m)* rather than a sentence. Check the unit: per cent, million, nights.

Common mistake. Confusing *thirteen* and *thirty*, or *fifteen* and *fifty*. The *-teen* numbers are stressed at the end; the *-ty* numbers at the start.

Practice

1. How many visitors came last year?
2. How many came the year before?
3. What was the hotel occupancy rate?
4. Did the average stay go up or down? From what to what?
5. What fraction of visitors came from other Gulf countries?
6. What is the target, and for which year?

▼ **Show answers**

1. 3.2 million
2. 2.8 million
3. 74%
4. Down, from 5 nights to 4.6 nights
5. Nearly a third
6. 4 million visitors by 2027